

and Bactrians and Sogdians to the north, which are in fact nearly of one speech with (Persians and Medes).¹ It is not quite clear whether all four Aryan folk-names are subject to εἰσίν, or only the last two. But anyhow the Persians and Medes are assumed to be of Aryan speech, and yet there is still a qualification suggesting that the Aryan speech does not cover the whole of their area even in Strabo's day. The Aryan character of the Sogdians has been shown to us finally by the extensive new documents, but of course these are of a still later date. So also are the Manichæan MSS. from Turfan, which include Middle Persian and some specimens of a dialect supposed by Müller to be the language of Khorassan, "the refuge of the Manichæans" (Flügel).²

I should not wish to press very far any conclusions

¹ ἐπεκτείνεται δὲ τοῦνομα τῆς Ἀριανῆς μέχρι μέρους τινὸς καὶ Περσῶν καὶ Μήδων καὶ ἔτι τῶν πρὸς ἄρκτον Βακτριῶν καὶ Σογδιανῶν · εἰσὶ γὰρ πῶς καὶ ὁμόγλωττοι παρὰ μικρόν (p. 724).

² There are some features in the scanty relics of this dialect which bring it nearer Avestan than the bulk of the MSS. Thus the numeral *four* is here *catfār* instead of *cahār* (*cafār* once, p. 46): *five* is *panj*, *pancamīk* (ordinal), against *panz*. One document (p. 101) shows the word *zāvar*, with the M.P. *zōr* (=strength) in the Pahlavi part of the same fragment: I note five other instances of *zāvar* in Müller's texts, and assume that these survivals are due to dialect-mixture. Specially interesting are the small fragments on p. 98 f. which give the *panj marlāspandlīh*, "five holy elements"—the last word is doubtful; they are 'artāv *fravartīy*, "pure ether (spirit)," *vāt*, "wind," 'artakhūušl, "pure light," 'āp, "water," 'ātar, "fire." In the other texts (M.P.) we have *vād*, 'ab, *adūr*. To *fravartīy* we must return, only noting here that both it and *arta* show *rt* against the peculiar Avestan *sh* (*aša*, *fravaši*). Once more we have *δβarā*, "door," which is nearer Avestan than *dar* of the M.P. texts. But these do not bring us yet anything peculiar to the Avestan dialect.

that might be drawn from the affinities I have thus sketched. They lead us, I think, to realise more effectively the consequences of the fact that Media is the Western limit of Iranian language in ancient times. Except for the perplexing Indian (or Aryan) gods at Boghaz-keui and the assumed Iranian names of Mitanni chiefs, near the middle of the second millennium, we have no sign of Aryan language west of the forty-second meridian, to which limit the Medes and the Karduchi (Kurds) represent the Iranian branch.¹ Iranian speech manifestly claims more and more of the ground as we go east. It is, therefore, at least natural to suggest that Media was the resisting medium in which the Iranian migration westward was arrested, only a proportion of the population being affected by the language invasion from Persia. The net result is that linguistic probabilities tend to reinforce the inference, drawn above on stronger grounds, that the Magi were part of the indigenous population of Media. They may have been sooner or later assimilated to the Persians in speech, but in racial characteristics, and in customs preserved by them from a remote antiquity as a sacred tribe, they owe nothing to either Aryans or Semites, and are purely aboriginal.

¹ Can the Kurds represent a swarm of nomads that left the main stream and struck southwards before reaching the north of the Caspian? The Sarmatae, just the other side of the Caucasus, and the Ossetes who still hold the Caucasus region, mark this path of Iranian migration. We could account for the Iranian chiefs of the Mitanni in this way. As to Boghaz-keui, we must be content to wait for more information, and hold ourselves prepared to tear up some pet theories, if necessary, when it comes. On the Iranian character of Mitanni names I should be sorry to dogmatise. Have we really evidence enough? (Compare p. 423 n.².)

Having attempted thus to answer the question as to the affinities of the Magi on the eastern side of their native land, we may proceed to ask whether they had affinities on the west. It will be convenient to enlarge the question to include Parsism as we have it, whether Magian or Iranian, reformed or unreformed. How far, then, is Babylonian civilisation responsible for Avestan ideas? There is a strong party among Oriental historians who are bent on finding Babylon everywhere. I am not an expert in Semitic matters, and shall not even ask the obvious questions as to the evidence on which we are to regard the Babylonian mind as the one great original force in Oriental thought. But before I shut myself up within my own proper corner, I cannot help expressing satisfaction in some signs of the times. I am not listening for the shout, "Babylon the Great is fallen," from serried ranks of scholarship; but some check to the extravagance of a few learned enthusiasts is not unwelcome. My predecessor in this Lectureship, Dr Farnell, has in his *Greece and Babylon* rescued Hellas from absorption; and believers in the most original nation of history will read his concluding sentence with relief:—

So far, then, as our knowledge goes at present, there is no reason for believing that nascent Hellenism, wherever else arose the streams that nourished its spiritual life, was fertilised by the deep springs of Babylonian religion or theosophy.

With this we may set the rebuke which professional astronomers have been administering to a distinguished group of Assyriologists who have built up a system of "Astral Mythology" without apparently

thinking it necessary to learn some astronomy. The glory of Hipparchus as the first discoverer of precession has been restored ; and with all our admiration for a pioneer civilising agency, we are no longer obliged to credit Babylon in the second or third millennium with the lead in every department of thought.¹

So far as I can see, Parsism is as independent of Babylon as was Hellenism itself. Its silences are very eloquent. I may put first one that follows naturally on the topic just referred to. / If Babylon was not quite so learned in star-lore as some enthusiastic imaginations have feigned her, there can of course be no question as to the prominence of astrology in her religion. And in Parsism this is most conspicuously absent. ~~We have seen that~~ the Magi had a great reputation as astrologers, but ~~that~~ it was in their own right : astrology never was at home in Parsism proper. Few sacred books have less about the stars than the Avesta. There is Tishtrya, the obvious exception that proves the rule. But it has been already observed that there is no suggestion of astrology in the use thus made of the most brilliant of the fixed stars—only a very natural mythology, accounting for the fact that Sirius disappears in the Sun's rays just during the hottest season of the year, the "dog days."² In early Parsism there is never a sign of that element which was so pervasive in Babylonian theology, nor does the later development show any invasion of the kind.

¹ See the severe criticism of "Astral Mythology," by Mr E. W. Maunder of Greenwich Observatory, in the *London Quarterly Review* for October 1912.

² On this subject see p. 23 f.